

Chapter 54-1

In the darkness, all of one's senses become amplified.

For instance, Liang Shi could clearly hear the intense sound of heartbeats—whether it was hers or Xu Qingzhu's, she couldn't tell.

Most likely it was hers.

It was even clearer than the piano music on stage.

Her hand gripped Xu Qingzhu's tightly, while her other arm wrapped around Xu Qingzhu's neck.

In an extremely awkward position, she was being held in Xu Qingzhu's embrace.

And her buttocks were indeed pressed firmly against Xu Qingzhu's thighs.

...

This was truly exceptionally embarrassing.

Liang Shi felt her entire body burning with heat, while simultaneously feeling grateful that they were in darkness.

Her flushed face wouldn't be seen by Xu Qingzhu.

But unexpectedly, Xu Qingzhu said in a low voice: "Teacher Liang, your hands are so hot."

Liang Shi immediately withdrew her hand.

At the same time, she quickly stood up, rising too hastily and hitting her leg against the armrest.

Fortunately, the armrest had a fabric cover and was curved in shape.

Even so, it still hurt enough to make her suck in a sharp breath.

Rather awkward.

The couple who had caused her such awkwardness had already stopped their argument, and the man apologized to Liang Shi.

Usually magnanimous Liang Shi, however, said harshly: "Don't argue in public places."

The young man apologetically apologized again.

Liang Shi couldn't say anything more.

This pianist enjoyed international acclaim. Before coming, Liang Shi had researched her background, so she was familiar with her pieces.

Just from the tickets sold in the concert hall, one could tell how remarkable this pianist was.

Attending a concert was a rather refined way to date. The system's initial hint had also been: in darkness, ambiguity easily grows.

But having made such a blunder right from the start, Liang Shi felt: the system was never reliable.

Her thigh still ached faintly from hitting the armrest, and rubbing it gently didn't help ease the pain.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu beside her was already listening intently to the piano music.

Xu Qingzhu maintained good posture, sitting straight with her arm casually resting on the armrest, her two slender legs pressed together.

Soon, Liang Shi also became immersed in the concert.

Her way of showing immersion was—sleeping.

After experiencing so much during the day, her brain had been running at high speed for a long time, and her body also felt fatigued. The current environment and atmosphere would make anyone relax.

Liang Shi also forgot when exactly she lost consciousness. Amidst the undulating piano music, her head tilted and drooped, falling onto a support.

Xu Qingzhu had originally been immersed in the piano music as well. This pianist was one she really liked and could rank in her personal top favorites.

The unpleasant emotions from arguing with her father at home during the day were also gradually dissipating during this performance. But unexpectedly, before even half an hour had passed, brown long hair cascaded in front of her.

In a very strange position.

The long hair covered half of the area above her abdomen, and then a head slowly settled on her shoulder.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Her attention was distracted, and she turned her face to look at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi's eyes were tightly closed, her breathing rhythm slow, her bright red lips somewhat moist, and her entire face very pale.

Ever since she stopped wearing heavy makeup, she looked much more natural overall.

She was even more beautiful than when she wore heavy makeup.

It wasn't that Xu Qingzhu hadn't seen her up close before.

But those times were at home.

Now being outside, she seemed particularly nervous.

There was a feeling of stealing glances while afraid of being discovered.

Liang Shi wasn't peaceful even in sleep. The place that had been hit by the armrest was still hurting. She unconsciously reached out to rub it in her unclear state of consciousness, but quickly gave up again.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her sleeping face, then slowly reached her hand toward the spot where she had been hit.

Her fingers gently massaged her leg, and only then did Liang Shi's constantly furrowed brow finally relax somewhat.

Author's Notes: (unsure translations)

Chapter 54-2

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When Liang Shi woke up again, the piano music in the concert hall had already stopped.

The audience had all left as well, with only a few staff members still cleaning up the aftermath.

Liang Shi almost instinctively sat up straight, then stole glances at the person beside her—once, twice, then a third time.

Xu Qingzhu didn't have much of a reaction. Seeing that Liang Shi was awake, she stood up directly, "Let's go, time to go home."

Liang Shi: "..."

She pressed her brow, feeling somewhat annoyed.

However, Xu Qingzhu walked very quickly and had already reached the concert hall entrance. She immediately got up to chase after her, but when she stood up, her legs felt a bit weak—she must have really slept for quite a while.

After catching up to Xu Qingzhu, Liang Shi asked: "How long did I sleep?"

"Not long," Xu Qingzhu said.

When they walked out of the concert hall, Liang Shi saw people coming and going outside, many of whom also seemed to have just come out, which made her believe Xu Qingzhu's words.

But before her heart could settle back down, Xu Qingzhu said: "The concert was only an hour total—how long could you have slept?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Why did it feel like she was being sarcastic?

But Liang Shi indeed knew that what she did was inappropriate. She coughed lightly and apologized: "I'm sorry, I didn't do it on purpose."

Xu Qingzhu was surprised: "I'm not blaming you."

"I blame myself," Liang Shi said. "We agreed to come listen to the concert together, to cultivate our sentiments, but I slept for such a long time. It's my fault."

"No," Xu Qingzhu said. "You really didn't sleep for very long—about half an hour."

Liang Shi: "..."

The concert was a total of one hour, and she slept for half an hour.

Half the time...

It really was quite inappropriate.

Liang Shi said guiltily: "How about I treat you to a movie next time to make up for it?"

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "Really feeling that guilty?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Yes."

"Then you..." Xu Qingzhu paused, pointing to her own shoulder and said: "Wash my clothes for me."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Xu Qingzhu said nonchalantly: "You drooled on my shoulder."

Liang Shi: "???!!!"

How could that be?

She was someone with very good sleeping habits!

But seeing Xu Qingzhu speak so confidently, she hesitated.

It must be true, right?

Xu Qingzhu didn't look like she was lying.

So after two seconds of silence, Liang Shi said gently: "Alright, I'll hand-wash it for you when we get back."

Xu Qingzhu stared at her, then after a moment couldn't help but laugh out loud: "Silly."

Liang Shi: "...?"

She had just woken up and was still a bit dazed, believing Xu Qingzhu's words completely.

But hearing her say this, she immediately felt a bit hurt and asked unhappily: "What's wrong?"

There was a hint of reproach in her tone.

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu laughed and said: "I was just teasing you. You only slept for how long—how could you possibly drool?"

Liang Shi was speechless: "Fine."

Seeing her reaction was off, Xu Qingzhu moved closer and asked: "Are you angry?"

Liang Shi shook her head, but her tone was sullen: "No."

She walked forward, but Xu Qingzhu grabbed her wrist, forcing her to stop.

Xu Qingzhu said: "You say you're not angry, but who are you showing that long face to?"

Liang Shi remained silent with a sullen expression.

After a long while, she sighed: "I'm not angry at you."

"Then what's wrong with you?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi felt a bit embarrassed to say this, so she hesitated for a long time before speaking.

"I'm angry at myself," Liang Shi said sullenly. "I was the one who first asked you to come to the concert, but I fell asleep after just listening for a few minutes and even leaned on your shoulder, causing you to not be able to listen properly either. I..."

For Liang Shi, who was accustomed to not burdening others, this was psychological pressure.

But unexpectedly, Xu Qingzhu laughed after hearing this: "Your way of thinking..."

She paused, changing what she was originally going to say—"isn't very good"—to "is actually quite nice, considering others."

Liang Shi: "..."

She said apologetically: "Xu Qingzhu, I'm sorry. Let me treat you to another concert to make up for it."

Xu Qingzhu shook her head and said against her conscience: "Actually, I don't really like concerts either."

Liang Shi: "Huh? But you were listening so intently just now."

Xu Qingzhu said without batting an eye: "I was pretending."

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu patted her shoulder: "Teacher Liang, if you really feel guilty, go buy me some cotton candy¹, and I'll forgive you."

Liang Shi: "?"

Footnotes: ¹ Cotton candy: A spun sugar confection popular at festivals and street food stalls

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Not far away, there were vendors selling cotton candy, candied hawthorn¹, and various other snacks.

Liang Shi immediately ran over to buy some, but when she arrived, there was only one cotton candy left, and another man also wanted to buy it.

Liang Shi and he spoke almost simultaneously: "Boss, I want this cotton candy."

The vendor looked troubled: "There's only one left."

Liang Shi was usually very easygoing. In situations like this, she would definitely say generously: "Then let him have it."

But this wasn't for her to eat—it was for Xu Qingzhu.

So she couldn't give it up.

Just as her mind was racing through all those arguments she could make with people, the other person said: "Let this young lady have it."

Liang Shi: "?"

She looked over, and the man scratched his head, saying embarrassedly: "Sorry about earlier in the concert hall."

Only then did Liang Shi recognize him—it was the young man who had bumped into her before the show started.

He looked quite young, probably still a student.

A college student who could afford a two-thousand-yuan concert ticket must also be quite wealthy.

Liang Shi didn't think much of it and thanked him.

She saw him settle for buying two candied hawthorn instead. Liang Shi wanted to pay for his purchase together with hers, but he beat her to paying, and even covered her bill as well.

Liang Shi: "..."

In that instant, her favorable impression of this young man doubled.

But she still insisted on giving him back the money. The young man said: "It's fine, it's fine. Consider it my apology to you. Go quickly and appease your girlfriend—I need to go appease my girlfriend too."

Liang Shi: "..."

Despite his young age, he understood quite a lot.

Before leaving, he even leaned close to Liang Shi and whispered: "Sister, your girlfriend is really beautiful."

Liang Shi: "..."

For some inexplicable reason, she replied: "That's my wife."

The young man's mouth formed an "o" shape, then he gave a thumbs up: "Married young—impressive!"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Then I wish you both a long and happy marriage!" The young man smiled brilliantly, and when his girlfriend called for him, he immediately ran over with the candied hawthorn.

His running figure was like a gust of wind. Watching him, Liang Shi couldn't help but sigh with feeling—being young was so wonderful.

You could do anything without restraint.

But as soon as he went over, his girlfriend said they were breaking up.

Liang Shi had already turned around to look for Xu Qingzhu, but she heard him ask with particular hurt: "Haven't I been good enough to you? Why do you want to break up with me?"

The girl's sweet, soft voice said: "I've fallen in love with Shen Siyan."

Listening to this, Liang Shi couldn't help but light a candle for that poor guy.

The young man was almost dying of anger: "How is it Shen Siyan again?! Do you really think Shen Siyan is someone you can reach?"

The girl: "I'm so beautiful—why couldn't I reach her?"

The young man was silent for two seconds: "Do you know what Shen Siyan's family does?"

The girl: "...I don't know. I heard they're very wealthy."

"All I can say is," the young man said helplessly, "you can barely even enter my family's door. Marrying into the Shen family—go dream about it."

The girl immediately started arguing with him.

Liang Shi listened to this drama, looking at the cotton candy in her hand that the young man had paid for, and chose not to mock them out of humanitarian consideration.

When she went over, Xu Qingzhu asked: "What happened?"

"That young man—his girlfriend had a change of heart," Liang Shi shared the gossip she had just learned. The commotion over there had already subsided. The girl had stormed off in anger, leaving only the young man standing there alone with two candied hawthorn.

Like a wooden post.

Xu Qingzhu also glanced over and made a "tsk" sound: "The girl missed out."

"Huh?" Liang Shi was puzzled. "What do you mean?"

"That's Zhao Xuning's cousin," Xu Qingzhu said. "Good character and excellent academically."

Liang Shi: "...!"

What a coincidence indeed.

Xu Qingzhu didn't say anything more after that, but Liang Shi suddenly remembered the name he had mentioned earlier.

"Who is Shen Siyan?" Liang Shi asked. "That girl thought she could marry Shen Siyan."

Upon hearing this, Xu Qingzhu almost choked, coughing several times before finally swallowing the cotton candy in her mouth.

Then she looked at the direction where the girl had left with an indescribable expression: "So young, yet dares to dream of anything."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Huayue International² is backed by Huaguang Group, and Huaguang Group is backed by the Shen family," Xu Qingzhu understood this world's business landscape better than her. "Shen Siyan is the only heir of the Shen family."

Liang Shi: "?!"

The same Shen family that was so difficult to even establish connections with?

Liang Shi suddenly felt that Zhao Xuning's cousin probably didn't stand much of a chance either.

But none of this was important—it was just a small matter in their world.

Xu Qingzhu ate half of her cotton candy before getting too full to continue. Liang Shi kept carrying it for her, and the two even went to have a late-night snack.

Just the usual kind of street food that they would normally never touch, the kind labeled as junk food.

The two wandered around until very late before going home.

Footnotes: ¹ Candied hawthorn (糖葫蘆): A traditional Chinese snack of hawthorn berries coated in hard candy and skewered on a stick ² Huayue International: A business company mentioned in the story as part of the complex corporate hierarchy

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[Ding dong! Congratulations host for completing the additional task: Watch a concert with Xu Qingzhu! Reward obtained: 29,999 yuan, which will be deposited into your account within ten minutes.

PS: The host completed this task very smoothly! We wonder if anything interesting and naughty happened with the target in the dark concert hall?

Additional PS: From zero to sixty is easy difficulty, but gaining lucky points after reaching the passing line is advanced difficulty. Host must continue working hard! Due to your increased personal needs, the Resentment Management Bureau has prepared generous material rewards for you in each task. Please be sure to work hard to complete them and obtain material rewards!

(Don't say we're stingy! That we took your wealth!)]

The current system had learned to be smart and no longer broadcast in real-time.

Before going to sleep, Liang Shi heard its broadcast message.

That chattering system had returned after receiving its punishment, its chatterbox nature fully exposed.

[Additional additional PS: Since you triggered the hidden task: Find Xu Qingzhu's biological parents, the Resentment Management Bureau hereby provides you with a clue: Xu Qingzhu's father has passed away, but her mother is still alive.

Warm reminder once again: if you forcibly expose Xu Qingzhu's background, there's a risk of triggering her PTSD¹. You must be careful, careful, and more careful!]

After hearing this segment, Liang Shi was basically certain.

Xu Qingzhu's father was Sheng Qinglin—her current nominal uncle.

But!

Wasn't this something she had known long ago?

The system's information was really useless.

Yet it felt its information was useful and was there taking credit: [I must be the most responsible system in the world! The water I've given you has already become an entire Pacific Ocean.]

Liang Shi: "...If you could tell me information about Xu Qingzhu's mother, I would agree with what you said."

System: [Sorry host, you'd better investigate that yourself!]

[Ding dong! There is no money in this world that can be obtained easily. Any money obtained requires paying a price!]

Liang Shi: "..."

Get lost.

After the system went offline, Liang Shi looked up some more information about Sheng Qinglin.

Same as before, nothing new.

So many years had passed, it would probably be very difficult to find anything.

Liang Shi touched the bracelet on her wrist—this should be the final clue.

But Qi Jiao had said that Su Yu's mother was called Su Mu.

Su Mu—

Also surnamed Su. Could she be related to Su Yao?

Liang Shi felt she still needed to investigate.

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The next day was sunny, and Liang Shi met with Zhao Xuning.

The blood-stained button she had sent for identification had results, but when Zhao Xuning handed her the identification report, she asked: "Have you ever seen a psychologist?"

Liang Shi asked back: "Is there something wrong with this button?"

Zhao Xuning pressed her lips together: "Nothing major. This is your blood."

"From when?" Liang Shi asked.

"When you were seventeen."

After Zhao Xuning finished speaking, she handed her the identification report, then looked at Liang Shi.

The results showed it was blood from when she was seventeen years old.

So what she saw that night was the original body at seventeen years old.

After a long while, Zhao Xuning suddenly said: "I met Gina."

Liang Shi was puzzled: "Who?"

"Should be your..." Zhao Xuning paused, "psychologist."

Footnotes: ¹ PTSD: Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder, a mental health condition triggered by experiencing or witnessing traumatic events